Ford Motor Company

James P. Vondale, Director
Automotive Safety Office
Environmental & Safety Engineering

March 6, 2002

Mr. Kenneth N. Weinstein
Associate Administrator for Safety Assurance
National Highway Traffic Safety Administration
400 Seventh Street, S.W.
Washington, D.C. 20590

Dear Mr. Weinstein:

Re: Ford Recall No. 02S33 – 2000 – 2001 Model Year Windstar – Trailer-Tow Connector / Sealer Skips

Summary

- Ford Action – Ford is conducting a voluntary safety recall involving Windstar vehicles with potential absence of body sealing in the area of the C432 electrical connector (on main wiring loom 14A005) to the trailer tow module on all 2000 – 2001 Model Year Ford Windstar vehicles.

- Number of Vehicles Involved – Approximately 543,257 vehicles (417,037 in the United States and Federalized Territories, 95,917 in Canada, and 30,303 in other countries).

- Affect on Vehicle Operation – In some of the affected vehicles, contamination of the C432 connector (on main wiring loom 14A005) to the trailer tow module may cause a low resistance short circuit between the power and ground pins in the connector, potentially resulting in overheating, smoke, and fire in the right rear of the passenger compartment.

- Service Procedure – Dealers will be instructed to inspect the C432 electrical connector and surrounding area for absence of body sealing and corrosion. If corrosion is present, dealers will be instructed to service body gaps, repair corroded connectors and apply a protective butyl patch to the connector assembly and body hole. If corrosion is not present but body sealer is nevertheless missing, dealers will be instructed to service body gaps and apply a protective butyl patch to the connector assembly and body hole.

Attached is the detailed information required by the applicable portions of 49 CFR Part 573 – Defect and Non-Compliance Information Report.

Sincerely,

James P. Vondale

Attachment
02S33 5d/pcw

ATTACHMENT

49 CFR Part 573 – DEFECT INFORMATION REPORT
02S33 – 2000 – 2001 MODEL YEAR FORD WINDSTAR

Pursuant to Part 573 of Title 49 of the Code of Federal Regulations, Defect and Noncompliance Reports, Ford Motor Company submits the following information concerning a safety recall action that it is voluntarily initiating.

573.5 (c) (2) -- Potentially Affected Vehicles

All 2000 and 2001 Model Year Ford Windstar vehicles built at the Oakville Assembly Plant are potentially affected.

Because these vehicles are not produced in VIN order, information as to the applicability of this action to specific vehicles can best be obtained by either calling Ford's toll-free line (1-800-392-3673) or contacting a local Ford dealer, who can obtain specific information regarding the vehicles from the Ford On-line Automotive Service Information System (OASIS) database.

573.5 (c) (3) -- Estimated Population of Vehicles Potentially Affected

Approximately 417,037 Windstar vehicles in the United States and Federalized Territories.

573.5 (c) (4) -- Estimated Percentage of Affected Vehicles with the Defect Condition

All of the involved vehicles have the C432 electrical connector. However, not all of these vehicles would be expected to have missing body sealer and experience corrosion of the connector.

573.5 (c) (5) -- Description of the Defect

Exposure of the C432 electrical connector to water and environmental contaminants may bridge the positive and ground pins, causing carbon tracking and corrosion that results in a low resistance short circuit in the connector. The primary source of water and dirt in the connector results from missing body sealer between the joint line of the floor pan and the right body side. The location is at the body quarter panel inner behind the right hand wheelhouse inner and in front of the right hand D-Pillar trough. Contaminants enter the electrical connector through the body gap from tire splash. A low resistance short circuit in the electrical connector may cause overheating, smoke, or fire in the right rear quarter of the Windstar.

Ford is aware of eight confirmed reports and three unconfirmed reports alleging fire related to this condition. There have been no reported accidents or injuries attributed to this condition.

573.5 (c) (6) -- Chronology of Events

On August 2, 2001, data indicated that there were 67 reports with six resulting in fire or smoke. Further analysis indicated that these occurrences were the result of a low resistance short in the C432 electrical connector. The cause of this short circuit was attributed to water and other contaminants that entered the right rear passenger compartment as a result of missing body sealer used to seal the gap where the floor pan, the right hand wheel house inner panel, the rear floor pan extension, and the right hand quarter inner panel are joined. When water is allowed to enter this area, carbon tracking between the power and ground terminals of this unsealed connector may lead to the melting or burning of the electrical connector.

As of February 12, 2002 there have been 8 confirmed and 3 unconfirmed reports alleging fires related to this condition. There are no known accidents or injuries attributed to this condition.

573.5 (c) (8) -- Service Program

Dealers will be instructed to inspect the C432 connector and the surrounding area for absence of body sealing and corrosion. If corrosion is present, dealers will be instructed to service the body gaps using Service Part Kit, called Kit-Seal Floor Pan, repair corroded connectors and apply a protective butyl patch to the connector assembly and body hole. If corrosion is not present but body sealer is nevertheless missing, dealers will be instructed to service body gaps using Kit-Seal Floor Pan and apply a protective butyl patch to the connector assembly and body hole.

There will be no charge to owners for this service.

573.5 (c) (9) -- Press statement and Dealer/Owner Letters

Ford does not plan to make a public statement concerning the subject matter of this action. A copy of the Notification letters to dealers and owners from Ford will be forwarded when available.

573.5 (c) (11) -- Recall Number

Ford has assigned recall number 02S33 to this action.